

**RAFT
DESIGN**

DESIGNING FOR *turbulent* TIMES AHEAD.

AI-Native Product Studio

→ AI product design → Brand systems → Product strategy → Design through build

APPROACH

Creating experiences to get you where you need to go, even as the water keeps changing.

AI is changing how people find, trust, and use everything, and most companies feel it without knowing what to do next. Startups move fast on engineering but haven't built the brand people stay for. Established companies have the trust, and are still learning to carry it into an AI-first world. We work with both.

Strategy, design, and build happen together, not handed off in sequence. What comes out is still elegant, still human, built to carry a company through water the rest of the industry hasn't learned to read yet.

Twenty years of work with the companies people already trust.

Adobe

Walmart 

VISA

HITACHI

Red Bull®

CHASE 

KDDI

 Mitsubishi

 *JAPAN AIRLINES*

CHANEL

◆ YOKOGAWA

 MITSUI & CO.,LTD.



TEPCO

 fitbit

EXPERTISE

Brand strategy & design

We define what brands stand for and how they show up. Positioning, identity, and systems built to scale and evolve. AI expands how we explore and create.

→ **Brand strategy, identity systems, positioning, art direction**

AI product design

Companies are still catching up on agentic AI. The model working is not the same as the product working. Design decides whether people trust it and come back.

→ **AI product design, agentic interfaces, conversational UI**

Products & platforms

Websites, apps, and platforms built for adoption. Design that adapts as the product grows and holds up when the team scales past the people who started it.

→ **Product design, UX, design systems, web, mobile**

Global brand & product

Brands and products that work in one market rarely survive translation intact. Meaning has to be rebuilt, not converted. Bilingual design leadership across the US and Japan.

→ **Global brand platforms, localization, bilingual leadership**

Design judgment, at the scale it has to survive.

540M+

Users and visitors interacted with our design in Walmart app

114%

Increase of monthly active users from our strategy

5X

Increase in add-on discovery and use in Express

PROJECTS

FOUR WAYS THIS LOOKS IN PRACTICE.

01 LegalOn

02 Adobe Express Photos

03 Walmart

04 Adobe Express Enterprise

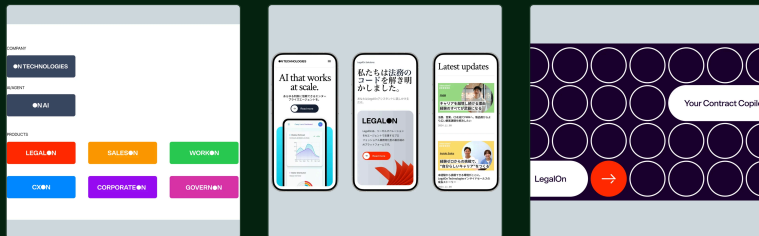
PROJECT 01

LegalOn's AI Brand Platform

Global Brand & Product Platform

LegalOn built Japan's leading legal AI, then expanded into a broader suite of AI-powered business products. The platform had to hold two opposing demands at once: one coherent global identity across seven products, and enough room for each to stand on its own.

The resolution was the “ON” concept: always on, always intelligent, always working.



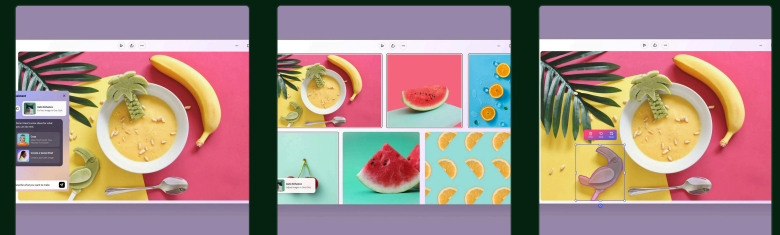


PROJECT 02

Adobe Express Photos

0-to-1 AI Product Design

Adobe wanted to democratize image editing. Adobe's new AI-powered desktop image editor transforms complex editing into one-click operations, making professional-quality enhancement accessible to marketers, SMBs, office workers, and consumers.



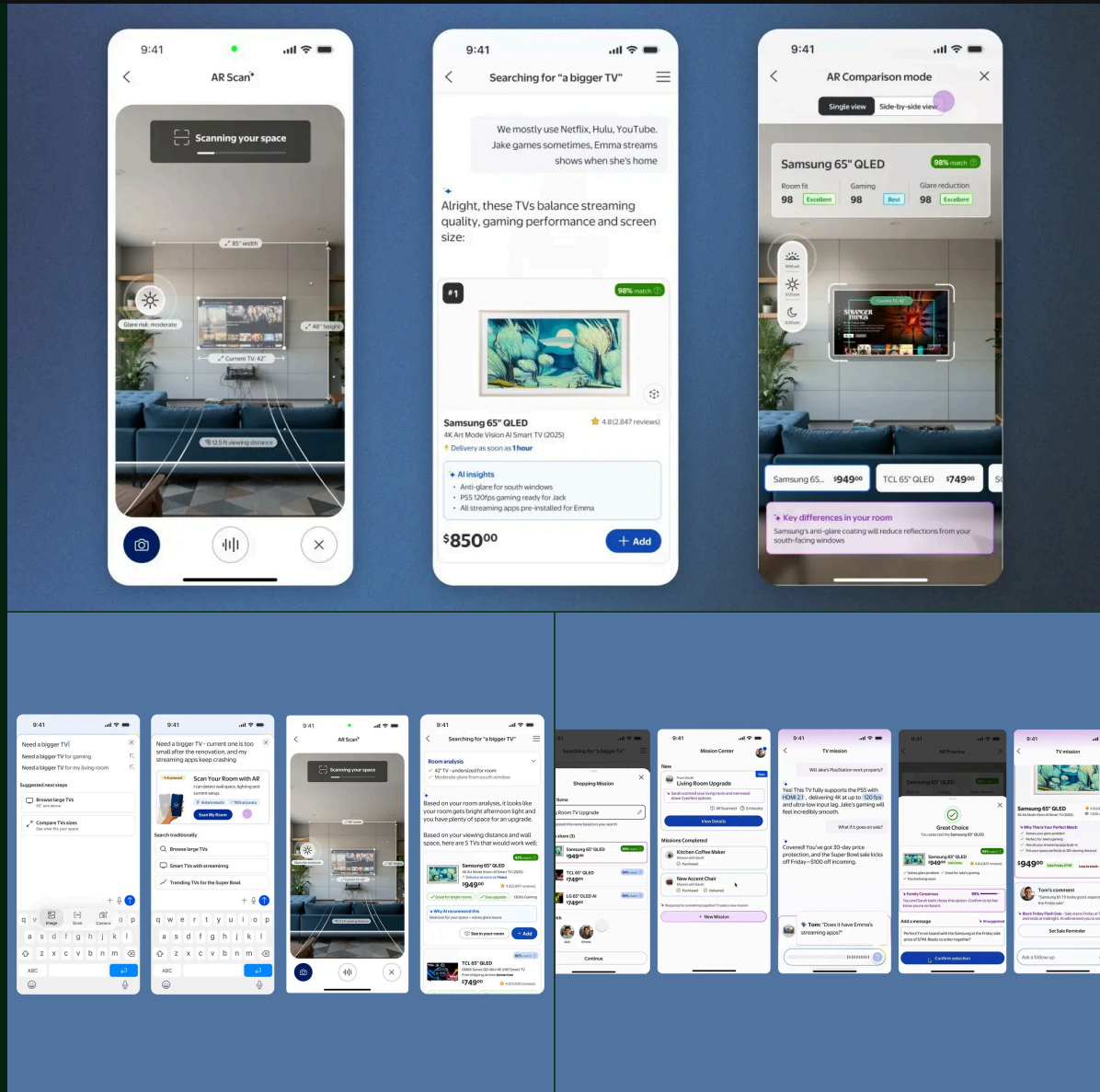
PROJECT 03

Walmart's AI-First Shopping Experience

AI Commerce Strategy & Product Design

Search at Walmart is used by millions every day, which made it both the highest-leverage place to introduce AI and the easiest place to lose trust. The position was that AI should layer onto search rather than replace it, tested in reversible ways on top of a stable core.

That framing became the foundation for multimodal search, an AI wizard with AR, and GenAI fashion discovery.





PROJECT 04

Adobe Express Enterprise Platform

Embed SDK + Plugin Ecosystem

Express had to work not only as an app, but as a platform other companies could build on and inside of — an embed SDK and an add-on marketplace, designed so third-party surfaces still felt like Express.

RESULT

5X increase in add-on discovery and use in Express.

BUILD

Designers hand off. Builders wait for specs. Neither is necessary anymore.

Start with the strategy

Time with Claude and ChatGPT thinking through the problem, the user, and the product logic — getting to a clear point of view before a single pixel or line of code exists.

→ **Problem framing, product logic, positioning**

Design and prototype together

Moving between Figma and AI tools to sketch flows, screens, and interactions. Close enough to the real thing to be tested and shared without waiting for engineering.

→ **Figma, Figma Make, rapid prototyping**

Ship it

Claude Code, Cursor, and V0 generate and refine working code. The build is directed, not delegated — knowing what you want, knowing when it's right, and knowing how to get there fast.

→ **Claude Code, Cursor, V0, deployed product**

The stack, and how we rate it.

Published openly, and kept current.

Claude

• core stack

Strategic briefs, long-form synthesis, prompt writing for coding.

Claude Code

• core stack

Front-end builds, design-to-code handoff, live iteration during client sessions.

Figma + MCP

• core stack

Design system source of truth, and the token pipeline that feeds Claude Code directly.

Cursor

• in rotation

Line-level work where you want to see the diff before it lands.

Claude Design

• watching

Prototypes, concepts, and design systems built conversationally.

Lovable

• in rotation

Prompts into polished, working web apps — the easiest path from idea to credible product.

STUDIO

Raft Design is an AI-native studio collaborating with companies in the U.S. and Japan on brand, product, and innovation.

Founded and run by Lance Shields, we have twenty years of building brand, product, and platform work across Tokyo and San Francisco taught the same lesson twice: what survives isn't the work built to impress. It's the work built to move. We work hands-on, owning the hard problems and building alongside product and engineering rather than handing off. Design leadership at Adobe and Walmart. Brand and product work with LegalOn, Visa, Hitachi, and Red Bull.

Most engagements start with a company that isn't sure how to move yet. We work natively in both Japanese and English, with design leadership across both markets.



Awards

Webby Winner — All-in-One AI-Powered Creativity App, 2024, for Adobe Express

Webby Winner — Best Nonprofit Website, 2016, for Thatsnotcool.com

Webby Winner — Campaign in Advertising, 2016, for “I am a Witness”

W3 Gold — Mobile Apps: Education, 2017, for Respect Effect

Japan Marketers Award — Silver: B2B Marketing, 2011, for Yokogawa

Good Design Award — Best Global Website, 2008, for Hitachi.com



Three ways to work together.

Projects

We take on projects like a traditional studio, from brand and product design to shipped experiences.

Fractional leadership

We embed as fractional design leadership when a team is scaling and needs senior direction.

AI-native consulting

We consult with teams that want to make their own design practice AI-native.

Engagements run from short diagnostic sprints to ongoing partnerships. Most studios hand off static designs for someone else to build; we take work through to functioning software.

The logo for RAFT DESIGN, featuring the words "RAFT" and "DESIGN" in a bold, sans-serif font, stacked vertically. The text is white and set against a solid blue square background.

**RAFT
DESIGN**

AI-Native Product Studio

Connect with me to explore your
project's potential.

hello@raftdesign.studio (415) 361-9584 raftdesign.studio

Hollywood, Los Angeles, CA 90068 · Tokyo, Japan

Designed by hand. Built by AI.